

Button Kin Games presents...



CALTRAP KAIJU!

**A monstrously fun and fast-paced disaster TTRPG
by Yvris Burke**

Caltop Kaiju

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Caltrop Kaiju

A gigantic, rampaging kaiju (giant monster) has shown up in your home town and is destroying everything! You must head out to observe the kaiju to find its weakness, then pass on what you know to the military at their secret base so they can defeat this monster - all while trying not to get eaten!

This is a solo TTRPG which can be played in ten minutes as a tactical puzzle, or in a couple of hours as a journaling/story game.

A Note on Difficulty

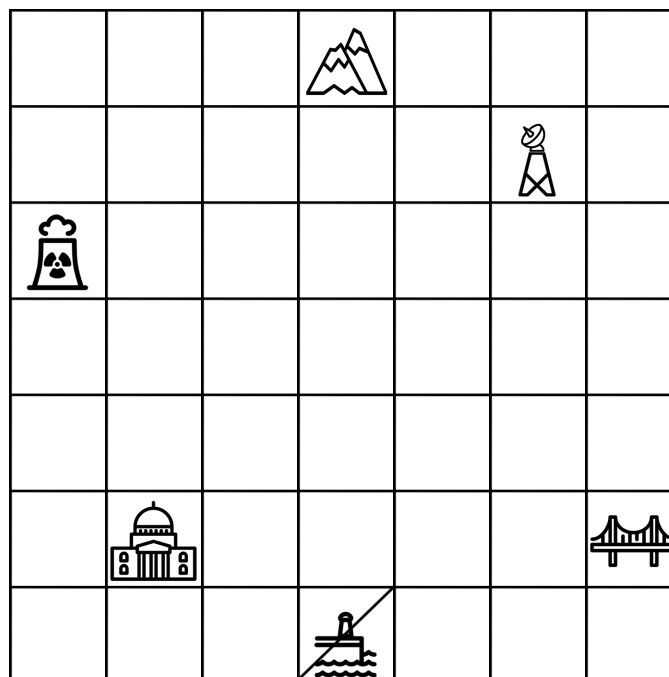
This game was designed through extensive play testing to be difficult but beatable by a savvy player. If you'd rather play on an easier "story" mode, consider giving yourself three points of **luck** to spend at the start of each game. Redeem these when the dice say you're dead, but you want to live another day.

You'll Need

You'll need at least one d4, or four-sided dice, colloquially known as a "caltrop". Preferably you'll have two in different colors. If you don't have dice to hand you can write the numbers 1-4 on separate bits of paper. Fold them up and pick one at random each time you have to "roll".

Next find a couple of counters - one for you and one for the kaiju. These can be anything small: traditional gaming minis, buttons, boiled sweets, even coins.

Draw a map like the one below, or print the one at the end of this document. Make the squares the right size for your counters.



Each square is a location in your city. Place your counter on the center north square of the map, at your home in the mountains. Place the kaiju on the center south square, at the docks where it has just come to land.

Find the Kaiju

You move first, then the kaiju. On your turn you can move one square in any direction or you can choose to hold still. The kaiju always moves three squares in a straight line.

To determine which way the kaiju travels, roll 2d4, then look up the result in the list below. It speeds things up if you have two dice which are different-looking and pick one to be the first, "left" digit.

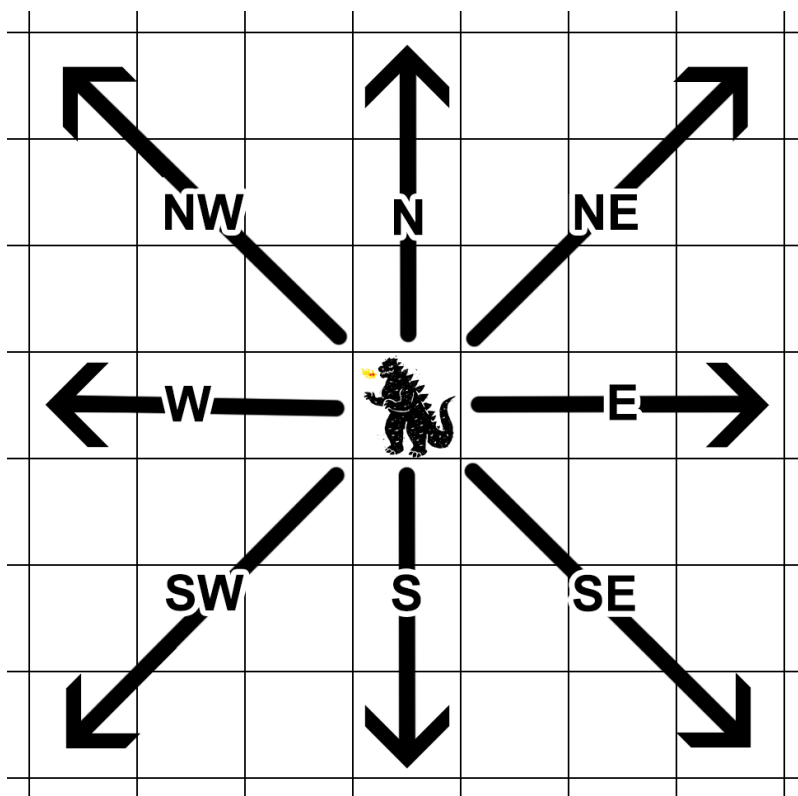
D44 compass directions

- 11 - North
- 12 - North east
- 13 - North
- 14 - North west

- 21 - North east
- 22 - East
- 23 - South east
- 24 - East

- 31 - South
- 32 - South east
- 33 - South
- 34 - South west

- 41 - North west
- 42 - West
- 43 - South West
- 44 - West



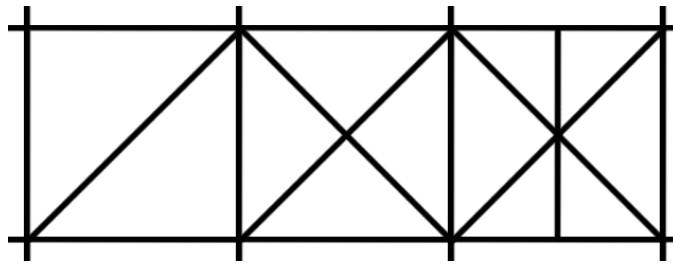
The kaiju moves in a straight line until it hits the edge of the map. If the kaiju hits the edge of the map before it runs out of movement, reverse the compass direction which is blocked and keep going.

For example, if the kaiju rolls to go east but it's already at the eastern edge of the map, it instead goes west. If the kaiju is heading south west and reaches the southern edge of the map, it carries on north west. If the kaiju rolls to go north west but it hits the north west corner, so it can't move north or west, it heads back south east.

Destruction

When the kaiju enters a location it receives a point of destruction. If a location receives three points of destruction it's completely destroyed. You can keep track of these points by crossing

off squares on your map as below. The first two squares are only partially destroyed, while the one to the right is completely destroyed. Notice that one location on the map always starts off with one destruction point marked: the docks where the Kaiju came to land.



The kaiju can move through destroyed locations, but you can't. If a location is destroyed while you're in it you are killed in a dramatic fashion. You can enter partially-destroyed locations, but they're full of falling wreckage, explosions, loose power lines, collapsing buildings, and other hazards. It's dangerous, so you need to roll to see if you get hurt.

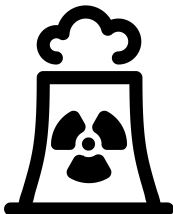
When you enter a partially-destroyed location, roll 1d4:

1-3 - You successfully navigate the wreckage, unharmed

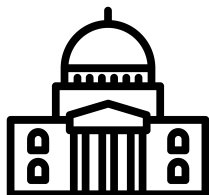
*4 - You have some kind of accident. You're **wounded**.*

Special Locations

Some locations trigger special events when they first take damage. When the kaiju passes through or lands on squares that contain these icons, look them up and apply the effects to your map.



The nuclear power plant is destroyed! The blast destroys this location and all the mapped locations around it as well (6 affected squares total).



City Hall is destroyed! The frightened populace riots, causing 1 point of destruction to this square and all the squares around it (9 affected squares total).



The telecommunications tower is destroyed! There's no cell service and no internet. TV and radio have gone dark. It'll take you 2 extra turns to find the secret military base.



The bridge collapses! There goes the main route out of town. Panicked civilians head north to safety in the mountains. Draw a line down the center of the map from top to bottom. You can't cross this line. You are stuck on one side of the map. If you're in the center when this happens, use your next move to pick a side. The kaiju can still move wherever it likes.



Your mountain home is destroyed! You are devastated and have Disadvantage on your next roll. Roll 2d4 and take the lower number.

Kaiju Sightings

When you come close to the kaiju, you experience a **sighting**. There are two types of **sighting**: the safer kind where the kaiju passes through a neighboring location, and the more perilous kind where it passes through the location you're in.

Each time you experience a kaiju **sighting** you have a chance to find its weakness. Your roll outcomes differ depending on the type of **sighting**. Don't worry too much if the dice are unkind, you'll automatically find the kaiju's weakness on your 5th **sighting**.

Perilous sighting

The kaiju passes over or stops in a location you're in, or you enter the location it's in, roll 1d4:

- 1 - You're unharmed, and you learn the kaiju's weakness
- 2 - You escape, and you learn the kaiju's weakness, but you're **wounded**
- 3 - You escape, but you're **wounded** and you didn't learn the kaiju's weakness
- 4 - You're killed in a dramatic fashion

Safer sighting

The kaiju passes through or stops in a location next to one you're in, or you enter a location next to the one it's in, roll 1d4:

- 1 - You learn the kaiju's weakness
- 2-4 - You can't get a good enough view before it moves on

Wounded

While you're **wounded**, roll every check with Disadvantage. If you're **wounded** twice you die of your injuries.

Disadvantage

Roll 2d4 and take the higher result.

Saving the Day

Once you know the kaiju's weakness you have a chance to save the day! You just have to find the secret military base. You'll find it after searching 1d4+3 locations. You can search a location by moving into it on your turn after you've learned the weakness.

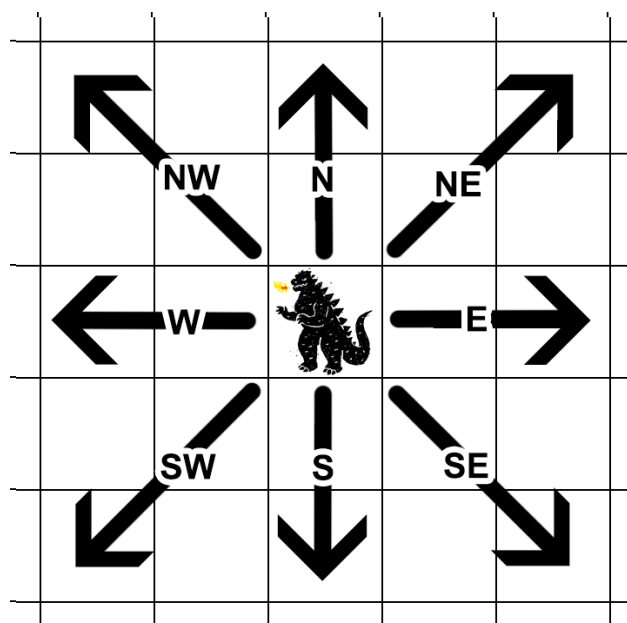
While searching you must always move into non-destroyed locations which you haven't yet searched. This includes partially-destroyed spaces, where you have to roll for mishaps as usual. Unless only previously-searched locations are available, then you can search a square again. Mark the squares as you go with a tick or a dot, so you can easily see which you've searched and how many times.

The kaiju will keep moving while you search, but now it has your scent and uses each of its turns to move as close to you as it can. It's searching every nook and cranny for you, so now it moves more slowly: just two squares in a straight line per round. It follows the usual rules about reversing direction when it hits the edges of the map.

If the kaiju catches you while you're searching for the secret military base, roll 1d4:

1 - you miraculously escape

2-4 the kaiju eats you, the city is doomed!



If you find their base, the military will exploit the kaiju's weakness immediately. The kaiju is frightened off, and escapes directly south towards the sea, causing destruction along the way. If it passes through a square you're in, roll to see if you survive this final encounter.

Putting the “RP” in TTRPG

Once you get used to the rules, Caltrop Kaiju can be played in under ten minutes as a quick-fire strategy game or puzzle. But underneath the game's mechanics there is a story unfolding. An action movie, at that. How much you lean into that is up to you!

One way to easily up the “story” aspect of the game is to journal as you go. Writing pulse-pounding accounts of every monster encounter. Describing the ruined locations you pass through, the ache of your wounds. The thrill of victory or the pathos of your untimely demise.

If you go this route there are a few questions you'll want to answer either before or during play.

Who are you?

Name, age, gender, star sign, and - perhaps most importantly - motivation. Why does your character feel that they are the one to find the kaiju's weakness? Maybe they're a

brilliant-but-discredited cryptozoologist? Or a monk from a sacred order, sworn to protect the land from these ancient monsters upon their return? Maybe you're just a regular citizen who happens to be obsessed with monster movies and know everything about kaiju?

What kind of monster is this?

When you first see the kaiju on the news, or from your lookout point in the mountains, what exactly do you see? Is it the classic, lightning-barfing lizard? An evil billionaire in a giant mech suit? Or something altogether stranger, cobbled together from parts of many animals on a dizzyingly-huge scale? Perhaps a sky-scraper-sized ape with lobster claws and a crocodile's snout? Go wild! Scare yourself.

What's in those empty squares?

You're going to pass through a lot of locations which don't have icons. What do you see? If you want some inspiration for types of locations you might find you can roll 1d4 on the following list:

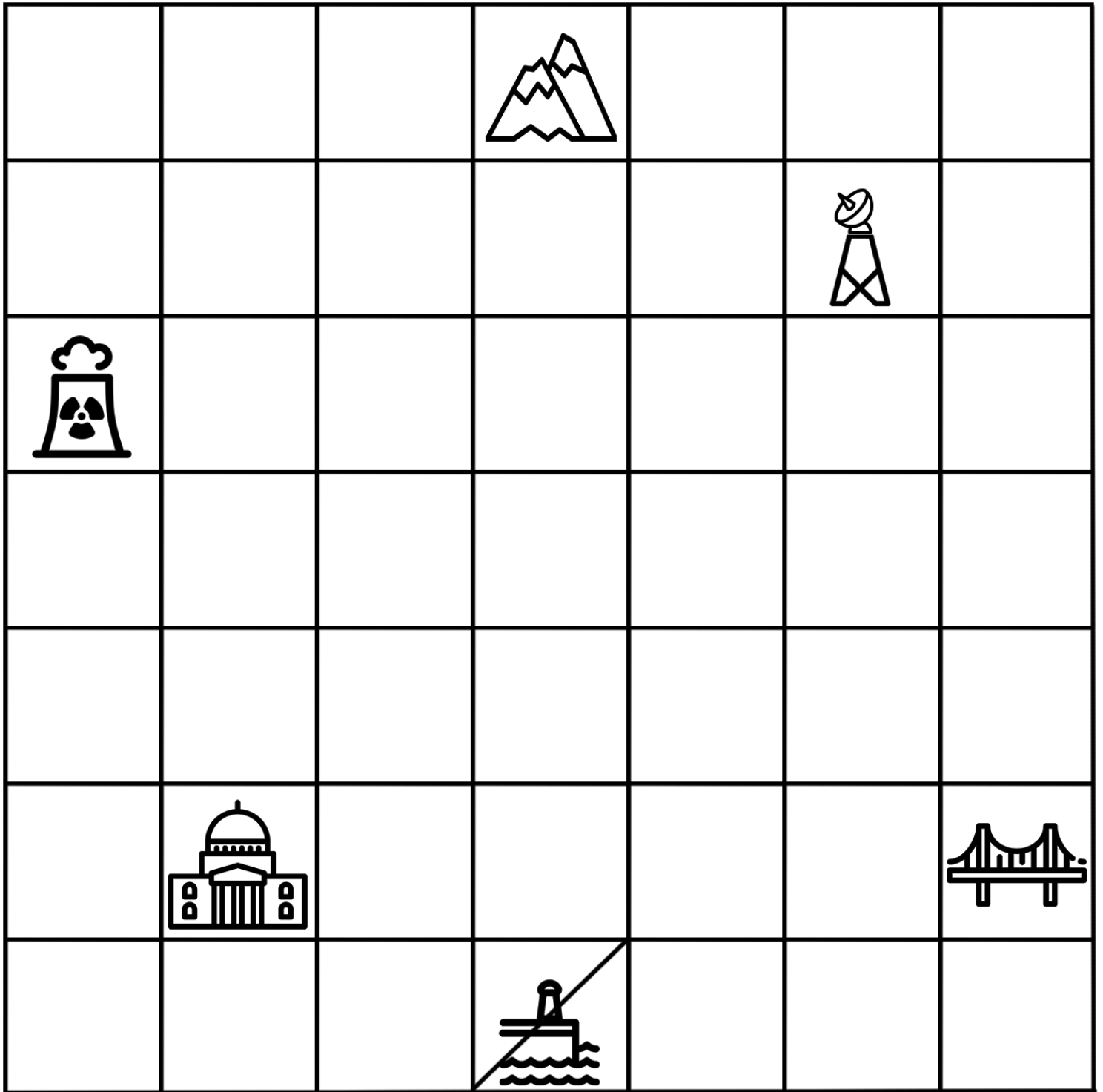
- 1 - Residential (houses, apartment blocks, nursing homes, trailer parks, etc.)
- 2 - Commercial (high streets, supermarkets, office buildings, shopping malls, etc.)
- 3 - Industrial (factories, warehouses, vehicle depots, sewage treatment plants, etc.)
- 4 - Leisure (parks, museums, theaters, cinemas, bowling alleys, casinos, etc.)

Where are your loved ones?

Who does your character care about, and where are they when the monster strikes? To increase the tension maybe you can add a few special locations to your map. Like your partner's workplace; your grandparents' retirement village; your best friend's favorite board game cafe. If the monster passes through these spots, roll to see if your people make it out using the same rules provided for your character.

What is the kaiju's weakness?

There are so many options! A specific weak spot on its bulky body, radiation, the sun, the common cold, music, bananas, bad weather, a giant laser pointer, the power of love... it's up to you to figure it out, and then figure out how the military might best use the secret once they have it.



Wounded? ☐

Disadvantage? ☐

Sightings: ☐☐☐☐☐

Searching turns: _____

